In 2007, Modi had reportedly hired a global PR agency, APCO, at a cost of $25,000 a month. The brief was simple—market Modi globally and sell the Vibrant Gujarat image. Modi insisted that he had not hired any PR company for his personal image building. But it's true that he was undergoing a visible makeover. His speeches became more deliberate; the chief minister's office would release well-sculpted images of a 'softer' man—reading a book, playing with children, flying kites—all designed to showcase a New Age politician. Select journalists and opinion leaders were flown to Gandhinagar and would write glowing reports on Modi's capabilities. Modi even got a book on climate change ghostwritten which was released by former president A.P.J. Abdul Kalam. He also took his first tentative steps towards a social media outreach by signing into Facebook and Twitter in 2009.

Always a natty dresser, he became even more trendsetting with his Modi kurtas, designed by the Ahmedabad tailoring shop Jade Blue. At different functions on a single day, he would always be dressed for the occasion, often changing three or four times a day. He was always fond of pens, only now the brand in the pocket was Mont Blanc, the sunglasses were Bulgari, the watches flashy and expensive. A former aide told me at the time, 'Narendrabhai sees himself not just as the chief minister of Gujarat—he is the CEO of Gujarat Inc.'

This was also a period when the Gujarat government launched an aggressive campaign to promote tourism. In December 2009, the Amitabh Bachchan starrer *Paa* was released. The film's producers were pushing for an entertainment tax exemption. Bachchan met the Gujarat chief minister who readily agreed on one condition— Amitabh would have to be a brand ambassador for the Gujarat tourism campaign. Till then, Bachchan was seen to be firmly in the Samajwadi Party (SP) camp—his wife Jaya was a party MP, as was his close friend Amar Singh. He had even done a '*UP Mein Hain Dum*' (UP Is Strong) campaign for the SP in the 2007 assembly election. Now, he would be identified with '*Khushboo Gujarat Ki*' (The Scent of Gujarat), with Ogilvy and Mather being hired for a massive ad blitz. Modi had scored another political point.